Memori CTI

THREAT ADVISORY · CISCO ISE

Cisco ISE zero-day is being actively exploited

A maximum-severity authentication bypass can hand unauthenticated attackers access to the identity control plane - with root-level command execution possible after exploitation.

Source: **Cisco PSIRT** · CVE-2026-76460 · 16 Sep 2026

THE THREAT AT A GLANCE

A 10.0 bypass with active exploitation

> Cisco has patched CVE-2026-76460, an authentication bypass in the API layer of Cisco Identity Services Engine and ISE-PIC.
>
> No credentials or user interaction are required. Cisco PSIRT says the flaw is already being exploited in the wild.

AFFECTED PRODUCT
Cisco ISE · ISE-PIC

CVE / SEVERITY
CVE-2026-76460 · CVSS 10.0

ATTACK PROFILE
Remote · unauthenticated

STATUS
Actively exploited · CISA KEV

WHAT THE BUG DOES

It skips the front door

> The vulnerability is caused by insufficient authentication control on an API endpoint.
>
> A crafted request can bypass the web-based management interface and give an unauthenticated remote attacker unauthorized access to the appliance.
>
> The issue affects ISE and ISE-PIC regardless of device configuration.

HOW THE ATTACK UNFOLDS

The exploitation chain

1. Attacker reaches an accessible **ISE / ISE-PIC API endpoint.**
2. A **crafted request** is sent without valid credentials.
3. The API's authentication control fails, allowing **management authentication bypass.**
4. The attacker gains **unauthorized access** to the affected device.
5. Post-exploitation access may progress to **root-level command execution.**
6. With root access, attackers can **hide or remove evidence** from the appliance.

WHY THIS ONE MATTERS

Why identity infrastructure matters

> Cisco ISE is a centralized policy platform used to manage users, endpoints and device access to network resources - often as part of Zero Trust enforcement.

IDENTITY

A compromise lands on a system that governs access policy.

Treat this as an identity and network-control incident, not only a web application event.

PRIVILEGE

Root command execution may follow successful exploitation.

That level of control materially increases persistence and cleanup risk.

FORENSICS

On-box evidence cannot be trusted in isolation.

Threat actors with root access may alter or remove exploitation traces.

EXPOSURE

Configuration does not remove vulnerability.

ISE and ISE-PIC are affected regardless of device configuration.

HUNT WHAT SURVIVES

Logs may be the only witness

- **Review access.log on every node.** Look for suspicious or unexpected usernames in distributed deployments.
- **Collect debug-inclusive support bundles** and inspect the API gateway access logs, including rotated/compressed files.
- **Cross-check off-box telemetry.** Firewall and network logs may retain evidence that an attacker removed from ISE.

```
admin#show logging application ise-kong/access.log | include dummyuser
```

> **Hunt pivot:** unexpected uploads initiated by ISE, downloads to ISE from suspicious external IPs, or unusual external communications around the suspected exploitation window.

PATCH NOW

Fixed releases

> There is no workaround that remediates the vulnerability. Cisco recommends upgrading to a fixed software release.

ISE / ISE-PIC RELEASE	FIRST FIXED RELEASE
3.1	3.1 Patch 12
3.2	3.2 Patch 11
3.3	3.3 Patch 12
3.4	3.4 Patch 7
3.5	3.5 Patch 4

→ **Temporary mitigation:** use infrastructure ACLs to allow only required management and control-plane traffic to affected devices.
ISE 3.0 is end of software maintenance and should be migrated to a supported fixed release.

CONTAINMENT & RECOVERY

If exploitation is suspected

- ✓ **Restrict management-plane exposure immediately.** Apply iACL controls while preparing the upgrade.
- ✓ **Preserve off-box evidence.** Pull firewall, proxy, NetFlow and other network telemetry before the investigation window rolls over.
- ✓ **Inspect every node** in distributed ISE deployments for suspicious access activity.
- ✓ **Re-image suspected nodes.** Cisco strongly recommends rebuilding affected nodes and restoring from configuration backup when malicious activity is suspected.
- ✓ **Patch all affected systems** to the first fixed release or later supported release.

Indicators & hunt pivots

On-Box	ise-kong/access.log and API gateway access logs - search for suspicious usernames; dummyuser is Cisco's non-exhaustive example.
Network	Unexpected uploads from ISE, downloads from suspicious external IPs, or anomalous outbound communication.
Behavior	Missing or altered evidence after suspected compromise may be meaningful because attackers can obtain root privileges.
Scope	In distributed deployments, review every node - not only the primary administration node.

Active exploitation changes the priority: **patch first, hunt broadly, and trust off-box telemetry.**

Stay vigilant. **Follow Memori CTI for more threat intel.**